

AI as a Learning Partner

A neurodivergent-friendly, inclusive impacting practice project grounded in my Pine Brook IGNITE teaching placement

Ask

Check

Choose

Change

Core claim

Students can use AI meaningfully when the lesson structure keeps their voice, choices, and thinking at the center.

What problem am I trying to solve?

Big idea

Students were excited by AI tools, but excitement alone did not guarantee thoughtful, independent learning.

What I saw in placement

- ▶ strong curiosity about AI
- ▶ high engagement with digital tools
- ▶ students moving quickly to whatever the tool produced

What worried me

- ▶ tool navigation overshadowing learning
- ▶ copying without checking
- ▶ uneven independence
- ▶ students losing ownership of ideas

Why this matters in EDF447

- ▶ EDF447 asks us to connect field experience to inclusive teaching practice.
- ▶ In my placement, inclusive teaching often meant balancing **support** with **independence**.
- ▶ That same tension appeared in AI lessons:
 - students needed structure to access the tool
 - but too much teacher rescue reduced agency
- ▶ This project grew from that question: **How do I teach AI in a way that supports diverse learners without replacing their thinking?**

Placement evidence that shaped the project

Source	What it showed	What I learned
Responsible AI and Canva Publishing	AI literacy needs chunked routines, visible success criteria, and clear proof of learning.	Students need AI instruction that is structured, not vague.
AI as a Thought Partner	Students benefit when AI is framed as a helper for brainstorming and problem solving.	The language around AI matters. It should support thinking, not replace it.
MagicSchool pilot lesson	Students needed modeling for login, prompts, topic choice, and deciding what to keep from AI output.	Responsible AI use must be explicitly taught.

My impacting practice artifact

Artifact

MagicSchool Student-Choice AI Partner Project

- ▶ A reusable three-session lesson sequence for Grades 3–5
- ▶ Students choose a topic, use AI as a supervised thinking partner, and create a product
- ▶ Product choices include a slideshow, poster, booklet, or simple site
- ▶ The instructional goal is not just “use AI”
- ▶ The real goal is: **plan, check, revise, explain, and stay the author of your own work**

The structure of the project



Across all three sessions

Keep the routine visible: **Ask, Check, Choose, Change, Explain**

What makes it neurodivergent-friendly and inclusive?

Neurodivergent-friendly design

- ▶ chunked directions
- ▶ visible routines
- ▶ reduced typing load
- ▶ prompt starters
- ▶ checkpoints before overload grows

Inclusive design

- ▶ flexible product choices
- ▶ teacher think-alouds
- ▶ partner roles
- ▶ drawing, dictation, or oral rehearsal before typing
- ▶ support for access without removing ownership

Key principle

The tool should adapt to the learner. The learner should not have to adapt completely to the tool.

Why AI can support learning well

- ▶ AI can help students brainstorm, narrow a topic, and organize ideas.
- ▶ It can reduce the blank-page problem for students who struggle to get started.
- ▶ It can support clearer explanations, simpler language, and step-by-step planning.
- ▶ For some learners, especially students who need structure or language support, AI can function as a low-stakes thought partner.

But only if...

students are taught to question, revise, and explain rather than copy and submit.

What the classroom evidence taught me

What worked

- ▶ student choice increased buy-in
- ▶ copyable prompts reduced friction
- ▶ teacher modeling made safer use possible
- ▶ partner talk lowered language load

What needed adjustment

- ▶ logging in and tab management took time
- ▶ some students treated AI output as final
- ▶ some topics were too broad
- ▶ success criteria had to remain visible all lesson

The deeper instructional shift

Big idea

I am not teaching students to get answers from AI. I am teaching students how to think with AI while keeping authorship, judgment, and responsibility.

- ▶ This is a digital-literacy goal.
- ▶ This is an inclusion goal.
- ▶ This is also a future-ready goal for classrooms where AI will increasingly be present.

Why this counts as impacting practice

- ▶ It is grounded in real teaching-placement experience, not a hypothetical future classroom.
- ▶ It responds to a recurring instructional need I actually observed.
- ▶ It produces a reusable artifact that another teacher could adapt.
- ▶ It connects educational technology, special education thinking, and responsible instruction.
- ▶ It moves from reflection to design:
 - What did I see?
 - What problem kept repeating?
 - What practical structure could improve it?

What I would refine next

- ▶ collect student artifacts from each product type
- ▶ save stronger classroom evidence from future reteaching
- ▶ refine timing for login and setup routines
- ▶ build a teacher-facing checklist for prompt quality, topic fit, and independence
- ▶ adapt a lighter version for younger grades or higher-support learners

Closing

Final takeaway

My impacting practice project argues that AI belongs in elementary learning only when it is taught through visible routines, inclusive scaffolds, and student ownership.

- ▶ AI should be a learning partner, not a shortcut.
- ▶ Support should open access, not replace thinking.
- ▶ Inclusive structure is what makes responsible AI use possible.